



59%
young
Indians
have jobs **

Poised on the promise of prosperity and armed with the accessories of success, 650 million Indians under 35 seem set to explore their future

33%
of youth in the
20-24 age bracket
are graduates
and more*

that refuses to follow in the footsteps of its parents. It has seen opportunities explode in areas that did not exist a decade ago, whether in television or in the Internet. It has seen creativity flourish and take new shape. It has also seen self-development evolve into an art. From grooming courses to dancing schools, the can-do people want to do it all. Even sports, an arena Indians were notoriously wary of entering. Suddenly, whether in training young sprinters or finessing feisty boxers, young India is learning the

sporting spirit. As Biswajit Gupta, Director, Centre for Culture, Media and Governance, Jamia Millia Islamia University, Delhi, says youngsters today are more focused, individualistic and self-oriented. "They are not protected and guided as we were." Indeed, as INDIA TODAY correspondents found, they were willing to listen to their hearts. Yet the optimism comes laced with anxiety. It's what sociologist Rabindra Ray calls the problem of plenty. And what Ashish Patil of MTV calls a "fargile invincibility", where the external skin of confidence cloaks a vast insecurity. Being successful is not eno-

10%
of the eligible
youth voted in
the last general
elections

ugh. One has to be seen to be successful, with the right college, right job, right partner. If life were a bumper sticker for India's young, it would read, it's all about loving yourself. Even as it bursts at its seams with assured ambition, it is assailed by the pressures of competition. Yes, 59 per cent of the youth are working. But there is the worry of student loans to be paid. Yes, 33 per cent of those between 20 and 24 are graduates or more, but the question is how valid is their degree. Then there is the competition for resources that are not growing as fast as the numbers are. Even as young people in villages want to leave faster than the cities will have them, the metropolitan youth seem determined to chase individual riches. Sociologist Dipankar Gupta doesn't blame them for being obsessed with consumerism. "If they are mercenary, it's because we, the previous generation, let them down by indulging in corruption and playing politics of the lowest order." If they believe in short cuts, it's because they've seen their elders wasting democracy.

So as they stand at the beginning of a decade where they will get jobs, have babies, build houses and perhaps even communities, their prime motivation may well be themselves. "What's in it for I, me, myself?" Hearteningly though as some of stories in the next few pages show, it is not always so. It could be an experiment in Pune where an undergraduate has set up a network to help others crack the competitive examination code. It could be future engineers in Hyderabad who break away for weekends to help impoverished youngsters learn vocational skills. At other times, it could be a mentor who lends a helping hand, an innovator who empowers students to create a new technology network in Ahmedabad, or an athlete who has unfinished business with the world. Anyone who enables young people to embrace their dream.

with Sumaiya Khan and
Gunjeet Sra

*Rajiv Gandhi National Institute of Youth Development; **Census 2001